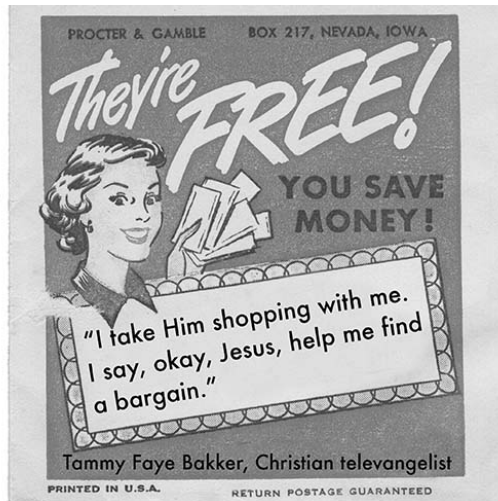




So, have coupons become defunct in the fight to gain consumer's trust and their spending money? Not according to a pilot program at the C&K Market in Oregon. While digital coupons are all the rage, a so-called "retro-marketing" promotion at C&K Market in April of 2010 credits paper coupons for a double-digit increase in total store sales. One store even saw a 44 percent increase in sales from the year before. C&K operates sixty stores in Oregon and California. Their traditional marketing method involved a direct-mail booklet that contained thirty-two coupons. They were sent to loyalty cardholders at an Oregon store and five other hard-hit locations that seemed to be especially affected by the sluggish economy. Sales results showed that the coupons were achieving what C&K set out to do—build up its shopper base. While the stores are active on the Internet and social media, the success of the coupon booklet showed that the traditional paper coupon can still be effective in today's world.

From a marketing perspective, some things never change, and that means the mighty coupon will likely remain a valuable marketing tool. Ranging from their own store coupons to promotions like doubling manufacturer's